

Session 10: The Beginning and Nothingness

Key Takeaways

- Ancient creation accounts are about function rather than material existence.
- Things are thought to exist only when they are given a purpose and a name.
- Genesis 1 then is mainly about the purpose of the universe rather than its material creation. (While Yahweh is the creator of all things out of nothing, this may not be what Genesis 1 is about.)

Genesis 1:1-2: The Introduction and the Pre-Creation State

Genesis 1:1 NASB*

In the beginning, God created the skies and the land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In this verse, “beginning” (Hebrew: *reshit* / ראשית) refers not to a first point in time but to a preliminary period of time.

Job 8:6-7 NASB*

⁶ If you are pure and upright, surely then [God] will rouse himself for you and restore your rightful habitation. ⁷ Even though your ***reshit*** was insignificant, your end will be very great.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here, the entire period of Job’s life before his suffering is called the ***reshit***, the beginning period.

Jeremiah 27:1 NASB*

In the ***reshit*** of the reign of Zedekiah the son of Josiah, king of Judah, this word came to Jeremiah from the LORD, saying ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jeremiah 28:1 NASB*

Now in the same year, in the ***reshit*** of the reign of Zedekiah king of Judah, in the fourth year, in the fifth month, Hananiah the son of Azzur, the prophet, who was from Gibeon, spoke to me in the house of the LORD in the presence of the priests and all the people, saying ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice how the *reshit* of Zedekiah's reign extends over four years. The word here refers to the initial period of his reign before the crucial events of his downfall began.

"In Genesis, the 'beginning' (*reshit*) refers to a preliminary period of time rather than a first point in time ... This leads us to conclude that the 'beginning' is a way of labeling the seven-day period of creation described in the remainder of Genesis 1 rather than a point in time prior to the seven days ... It provides a literary introduction to the period of creativity that then flows into the ... rest of the book."

Walton, John H. (2011). [*Genesis 1 as Ancient Cosmology*](#). Eisenbrauns. 126-127.

Genesis 1:2 as the pre-creation state is described by the use of waters, darkness, and wilderness. Specifically, the land is described as wild and waste or in Hebrew, *tohu vavohu*. What is meant by *tohu vavohu*?

Other Uses of *Tohu* or *Vohu*: "Empty/Uninhabited/Wasteland"

Deuteronomy 32:9-10 NASB*

⁹ For the LORD'S portion is his people;
Jacob is the allotment of his inheritance.

¹⁰ He found him in a desert land,
and in the howling **tohu** of a wilderness;
he encircled him, he cared for him,
he guarded him as the pupil of his eye.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 24:10-12 NASB*

¹⁰ The city of **tohu** is broken down;
every house is shut up so that none may enter.
¹¹ There is an outcry in the streets concerning the wine;
all joy turns to gloom.
The gaiety of the earth is banished.
¹² Desolation is left in the city
and the gate is battered to ruins.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 45:18 NIV*

For this is what the LORD says— he who created the heavens, he is God; he who fashioned and made the earth, he founded it; he did not create it to be **tohu**, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: "I am the LORD, and there is no other."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalms 107:40 Instructor's Translation

[Yahweh] pours contempt on nobles,
and he makes them wander in a **tohu** that has no road.

This verse is related to Job 12:21, 24.

Uses of *Tehom*

The text continues with "... and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss" (Hebrew: *tehom*, Gen. 1:2). Below are other biblical passages that use *tehom*.

Job 38:16-17 NASB*

¹⁶ Have you entered into the springs of the sea,
or walked in the recesses of the ***tehom***?

¹⁷ Have the gates of death been revealed to you,
or have you seen the gates of deep darkness?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Jonah 2:5-6 NASB*

⁵ Water encompassed me to the point of death.

The ***tehom*** engulfed me,
weeds were wrapped around my head.

⁶ I descended to the roots of the mountains.
The earth with its bars was around me forever,
but you have brought up my life from the pit, O LORD my God.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In modern cosmologies, water is "something," but in ancient Near Eastern cosmology, the "cosmic sea" belongs to the pre-creation state, which is a neutral, functionless state of non-organization and lifelessness.

The Pre-Creation State and Biblical Ontology

Take a look at the following quotes from Dr. John Walton as he describes how the pre-creation state connects to biblical ontology.

"Genesis 1:2 ... describes the pre-cosmic condition as it was understood in Israelite thought. As in the rest of the ancient world [the pre-creation state] is not absent of matter, as the primordial waters are already present ... [T]hey are the functionless cosmic waters ... where order has not yet been imposed, the desert and cosmic waters above and below."

Walton, John H. (2011). [*Genesis 1 as Ancient Cosmology*](#). Eisenbrauns. 139, 143.

"Very little in ancient Near Eastern cosmologies [including Genesis 1] relates to the manufacture of the material cosmos ... Rather, they recount the organization and ordering of the elements of the cosmos as a functional whole. If we are going to understand ancient views about how the cosmos came into existence (creation cosmology), it is essential that we understand ancient views about what constitutes existence (creation ontology). In the ancient world, something came into existence when it was separated out as a distinct entity and given a function and a name ... this is a function-oriented ontology. This is in stark

contrast to modern ontology, which is focused on the material existence or structure of something. For us, the existence of the world is perceived in physical, material terms ... this is a substance-oriented ontology. ... [For the ancient biblical authors,] creation was about the establishment of the functioning cosmos, not about the origins of the material structure or substance of the cosmos.”

Walton, John H. (2006). [Ancient Near Eastern Thought and The Old Testament](#). Baker Academic. 180-181.

Three Elements of Disorder in Genesis 1 Solved

In the chart below, notice that the three elements of disorder in Genesis 1:2 all find parallels in ancient Near Eastern cosmologies, and each one is separately addressed in days one through three of Genesis 1.

Now, the land was wild and waste and darkness was over the face of the deep abyss	
	Day 1: Light contains the darkness
	Day 2: Waters separated and ordered
	Day 3: Dry land and edible plants emerge from the waters
Three Elements of Disorder in Genesis 1. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).	

Reflection Question

According to John Walton, what are ancient Near Eastern “beginnings” stories about? The universe’s material existence or something else? If something else, what?